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The Occult Court: ‘Alī Ṣafī’s *Boon for the Khan* (1522) as Timurid-Safavid Manual of Boozing and Battling Magic and Marker of Early Modernity

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ABSTRACT

The occult-imperial turn that defined the post-Mongol Persianate world saw a proliferation of grimoires as handbooks of court culture – one with Mediterranean roots. Here I contextualise and translate for comparative study a minor Persian manual of illusionism and trickery, *Boon for the Khan*, by the Herati Naqshbandī Sufi, preacher and occultist ‘Alī Ṣafī (d. 1533), as strategic window onto this turn generally and the politically and militarily fraught Timurid-Safavid, Sunni-Shi‘i transition specifically. Commissioned by a Qizilbash warlord in 1522, it emblematises the wider democratising, Renaissance ethos that is a distinctive feature of early modernities West and East, especially occult-scientifically; it was written to help make Safavid courtly and military life quite literally *stage-magical*. This wonderfully accessible manual of warlord magic – devoted to boozing and battling (*bazm u razm*) in a way no known previous grimoire in the Western tradition had been – marries ancient Platonic-Alexandrian occult philosopher-kingship to modern “occult democracy”.

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The science of magic and talismans joins
commoners to kings and kings to angels.

– BRETHREN OF PURITY¹

Ce roi est un grand magicien.
– MONTESQUIEU²

Political magic: few terms are more redundant. If we define magic as the technological management of perception, expectation and experience through the manipulation of bodies, words and images, as Islamo-Judeo-Christian grimoires (following Plato) regularly do, the political was and is magical as a rule.³ Occult scientists have therefore

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¹Epistle 51, in Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, *Rasā’il*, 4 volumes (Beirut: al-A‘lamī, 2005), 4/236: ‘ilm al-sihr wa-l-ṭilasmāt... *tulhiq al-ra’iyya bi-l-mulūk wa-l-mulūk bi-l-malā’ika*. As will be seen below, ‘Alī Ṣafī is an important heir to the imperial-occultist project of the New Brethren of Purity.

²*Lettres Persanes*, ed. and intro. Robert Loyalty Cru (New York: Oxford University Press, 1914), p. 34. Montesquieu’s (d. 1755) celebrated influence on modern democratic theories – painted in this work in Persianate terms – is here especially salient.

³Needless to say, the history of the English word “magic” is extremely embattled and frequently polemical; I use it here generically, but also in reference to the definitions of *sihr* as a natural (*tabī‘ī*) science and but one among many occult

often served as political scientists too, their numbers waxing and waning with the waxing and waning of empires over the last several millennia. By the same token, court ritual and imperial architecture have historically often been quite explicitly occult, and the king's body conceived of in astral-magical and alchemical terms as a talisman uniting and healing heaven and earth. But nowhere did occult science fuse with magical state more fully than in the post-Mongol, early modern Persianate imperial cultural continuum that was the Timurid, Aqquyunlu, Safavid, Uzbek, Ottoman and Indo-Timurid (Mughal) Empires, together constituting a new Chinggisid-Persian-Islamic world order.⁴ Breaking with venerable Islamic precedent in favour of a pan-Mediterranean one, all embraced a specifically Timurid Pythagorean-Platonic astrological-lettrist platform as default imperial cosmology and political science, and talismanic books, bodies and buildings abounded across Islamo-Afro-Eurasia to a degree never before seen.⁵

Faced with this embarrassment of philological riches, virtually any period Persian grimoire picked at random – almost all of which remain occulted in the modern historiography – serves as a strategic window onto this peculiarly Persianate occult-imperial turn. For most are courtly products, and the canons they construct fraught with contemporary political and technological significance.⁶

Just such a window I translate below to open it to comparative study: 'Alī Ṣafī's (d. 1533) *Tuḥfa-yi khānī*, or *Boon for the Khan*. Commissioned in 1522 by Durmish Khān Shāmlū, Qizilbash governor of Khurasan, this minor early Safavid epitome of a major late Timurid manual of courtly magic is an important missing link in the story of the occult-imperial turn at an especially sensitive and transformative Sunni-Shi'i political moment.⁷ Specifically, *Boon for the Khan* extracts, simplifies and localises the seminal Persian grimoire *Qasimian Secrets* (*Asrār-i Qāsimī*) penned by the author's famous father, Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī (d. 1505), Herati preacher, polymath, Naqshbandi Sufi and occultist, whose project to create an everyman's library in Persian became foundational to Persianate courtly and popular culture through the colonial era, from Ottoman Europe to Mughal India and beyond.⁸ Here 'Alī Ṣafī explicitly continues his

sciences ('ulūm gharība) in Arabo-Persian grimoires and encyclopedias of the sciences. See Wouter J. Hanegraaff, *Esotericism and the Western Academy: Rejected Knowledge in Western Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012); *idem*, "Magic", in *The Cambridge Handbook of Western Mysticism and Esotericism*, ed. G.A. Magee (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press), pp. 393–404; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition", *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5/1 (2017): 127–99.

⁴Ayşe Zarakol, *Before the West: The Rise and Fall of Eastern World Orders* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022).

"Islam-Afro-Eurasia" refers to the Islamicate sociopolitical continuum spanning the Afro-Eurasian ecumene from the Atlantic Ocean to the Indian and the Pacific by the sixteenth century.

⁵Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Early Modern Islamicate Empire: New Forms of Religiopolitical Legitimacy", in *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam*, ed. Armando Salvatore et al. (Hoboken, NJ: Wiley-Blackwell, 2018), pp. 353–75. Even Ronald Reagan (r. 1981–1989) had his court astrologer; see H. Darrel Rutkin, *Sapientia Astrologica: Astrology, Magic and Natural Knowledge, ca. 1250–1800*, volume 1 (Cham: Springer, 2019), v, 143, 434 n. 51.

⁶Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persianate Cosmopolis", *Journal of Persianate Studies* 11/2 (2018): 140–54.

⁷Literally meaning "redhead", *qizilbāsh* refers to the distinctively Twelver Shi'i headgear of the Turkic military clans responsible for establishing the Safavid state.

⁸Maria Subtelný, "Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsimī*: A Late Timurid Manual of the Occult Sciences and Its Safavid Afterlife", in *Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice*, ed. Liana Saif, Francesca Leon, Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Farouk Yahya (Leiden: Brill, 2021), pp. 267–313; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Qizilbash Magic: An Edition of 'Alī Ṣafī b. Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī's *Book for Majd al-Din*, Exemplar of Timurid-Safavid Sunni-Shi'i Occultism", *Iran Namag* 6/3–4 (2021 [2023]): 282–326. Specifically, Kāshifī's general procedure was to gorgeously adapt and synthesise Arabic classics for a contemporary Persianate audience. His adaptation of *Kalīla wa-Dimna* under the title *Lights of Canopus* (*Anvār-i Suhaylī*), for example, remained so popular for centuries as to be assigned as a textbook to British colonial agents in Mughal India. For a general survey of his project, see "Ḥusayn Vā'iz-i Kāshifī: Polymath, Popularizer, and Preserver", ed.

father's commitment to the democratisation of knowledge generally and occult science in particular – a distinctive feature of early modernities West and East.⁹

Short and sweet and fully decrypted, *Boon for the Khan* is not merely a book of magic for warlords, but an occult-political operation in its own right. Together with the rest of 'Alī Ṣāfi's oeuvre, it was expressly designed to help create out of the chaos of the Qizilbash conquest a seamless Timurid-Safavid Sunni-Shi'i continuum.¹⁰ That 'Alī Ṣāfi more than succeeded in his design is testified to by the vigorous high Safavid occult-philosophical culture of the turn of the seventeenth century, of which the Safavid recension of *Qasimian Secrets* is a veritable who's who, and which saw the revolutionary redesign of Isfahan itself into a Pythagorean-Solomonic talismanic city as apotheosis, with the Tāj Maḥal, of the Timurid imperial style.¹¹

'Alī Ṣāfi's religiopolitical method, like his father's, was straightforward: draw exclusively on medieval and modern Sunni sources, then synthesise, organise, beautify, streamline and canonise them within a thoroughlygoingly imamophile framework. (This synthesis is emblematised by Kāshifi's 'Alid martyrology *Rawḏat al-shuhadā*, which became synonymous with Twelver Shi'i shrine pilgrimage ritual under Safavid auspices and has remained so to the present). Thus does this Herati preacher and Naqshbandi Sufi (author of the definitive history of that stridently Sunni order) organise his bestselling *Amulet of Protection from the Trials of Time* (*Ḥirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*) – among the most comprehensive manuals of lettrist magic of the sixteenth century, and the most explicitly political – according to a 5-5-12 pattern in honour of Those of the Mantle¹² and the Twelve Imams. His more portable epitome of the same, *Boon for Majd al-Dīn* (*Tuḥfa-yi Majdiyya*), also produced in the early 1520s for a Qizilbash political appointee, has a 3-12 pattern, and *Boon for the Khan* a 2-12 pattern for the same Twelver reason: in all three works our Sunni occultist exalts the Holy Family as a master model for the Islamic Occult Court.¹³

Maria E. Subtelny, special issue of *Iranian Studies* 36/4 (2003); Maria E. Subtelny, "A Man of Letters: Hoseyn Va'ez Kasefi and His Persian Project", in *The Timurid Century*, ed. Charles Melville (London: I.B. Tauris, 2020), pp. 121–34; *eadem*, "Kāsefi, Kamāl-al-Dīn Ḥosayn Wā'ez", in *Encyclopaedia Iranica*, 2012, iranicaonline.org/articles/kasefi_kamal.

⁹Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Taḥqiq vs. Taqlid in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity", *Philological Encounters* 3/1–2 (2018): 193–249.

¹⁰On this Sunni-Shi'i continuity, see Kathryn Babayan, *Mystics, Monarchs, and Messiahs: Cultural Landscapes of Early Modern Iran* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002); Maria Subtelny, *Timurids in Transition: Turko-Persian Politics and Acculturation in Medieval Iran* (Leiden: Brill, 2007); on the parallel Aqquyunlu-Safavid continuity, see John E. Woods, *The Aqquyunlu: Clan, Confederation, Empire*, rev. ed. (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1999); on the total embrace of Timurid imperial aesthetics by successor Safavid, Mughal, Ottoman and Uzbek courts, see Thomas Lentz and Glenn Lowry, *Timur and the Princely Vision: Persian Art and Culture in the Fifteenth Century* (Los Angeles: Los Angeles County Museum of Art, 1989), ch. 5.

¹¹Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Mīr Dāmād's *On Doffing*: Safavid Philosophy, Ritual Magic and Out-of-Body Experience", forthcoming; *idem*, "World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran", *Studia Islamica* 114/3 (2019): 378–431.

¹²The *ahl al-kisā*, comprising Muḥammad, 'Alī, Fāṭima, Ḥasan and Ḥusayn, and associated with the amuletic Hand of Fāṭima.

¹³That is, 'Alī Ṣāfi's oeuvres emblematised the phenomenon of Sunni-Shi'i confessional ambiguity especially common in occultist circles, but also a much broader social reality; it has variously been dubbed *tasannun-i isnā-asharī* or "Twelver Sunnism" (Muḥammad-Taḳī Dānīshpazhūh, Rasūl Ja'fariyān), "Alid loyalism" (Marshall Hodgson), "Ahl al-Baytism" (R.D. McChesney) and "imamophilia" (Matthew Melvin-Koushki). An edition of the *Tuḥfa-yi Majdiyya* is provided and introduced in Melvin-Koushki, "Qizilbash Magic". As for the 3-12 and 2-12 organising structures of the latter two texts, they may have been intended as an implicit gesture toward the Duality of Muḥammad and 'Alī and the Trinity of Muḥammad, 'Alī and Fāṭima, respectively, in relation to the 12 Imams.

Yet *Boon for the Khan* is not otherwise ‘Alid, since it does not treat of lettrism (‘ilm-i ḥurūf), the science of the Imams par excellence.¹⁴ Rather, like its model, *Qasimian Secrets*, it deals only with the sciences of illusionism and trickery as two of the classic Occult Quintet (*khamṣa-yi muḥtajiba*), so named after the esotericist code phrase *kullu-hu sirr* (KLHSR), “the whole is a secret”: *kīmiyā* (alchemy), *limiyā* (talismanry), *hīmiyā* (subjugation), *sīmiyā* (illusionism), *rīmiyā* (trickery).¹⁵ This phrase likewise encodes an epistemological, technological and sociological hierarchy, beginning with the most technically difficult, expensive and elite and ending with the easiest, cheapest and most accessible to the masses, suitable for public and party performance. (The Safavid recension of *Qasimian Secrets* greatly expands Kāshifī’s text to cover all five sciences.)¹⁶ Per his Qizilbash patron’s request, ‘Alī Ṣafī pushes even further in the popularising direction – with the express goal of making Safavid courtly and military life in Herat quite literally *stage-magical*.

As this wonderfully accessible little grimoire instructs us, we “Enlightened” moderns must be more wary of reflexively committing the category error of presuming all magic to be fake and hence unreal by definition: for here fake magic has very real psychological but also *physical* results, extending far beyond brain chemistry and the placebo effect (itself a new-fangled term for mind-over-matter magic). Creating a chimerical golem with the mere illusion of life nevertheless produces a blood potion that can cure serious diseases – even death! – when topically applied. Insta-agriculture to amaze and feed party guests actually produces edible fruits from a seed within an hour. “Magic cocaine” fuels your all-night orgies and “magic energy bars” sustain your soldiers on the march – and treasure dowsing funds both. The upshots of psyops are likewise very material, from the mind-control of animals for hunting and war to the terrifying projection of an airborne army of giants, from enhanced interrogation to psychic spying.

Weirdly enough, such medico-politico-military operations smack of modernity too. Not only are modern nation-states and transnational corporations imagined communities that terraform, linguaform, mentiform and bioform;¹⁷ few would claim that they do not have constant recourse to illusionism and trickery – and sometimes even psychic spying – in the quest to build or destroy empire, or that democratic societies ensorcelled by social and other media are not increasingly stage-magical as well. The peculiarly Timurid-Safavid product that is *Boon for the Khan* would hardly be legible as a *Boon for the President*, needless to say. But it embodies the simultaneously democratising and technologising imperial ethos that animated various Islamo-Afro-Eurasian early modernities – and much of global modernity, by ‘Alī Ṣafī’s definition, remains just as devoted to *deepfakery* and *warlord magic*.

¹⁴The two treasure-hunting operations ‘Alī Ṣafī gives, involving the application of letters to living animals for dowsing purposes, are a curious exception.

¹⁵Of these terms, *sīmiyā* (Ar. *simiyā*) is the most historically unstable, due in part to the confused polemics of anti-occultists like Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406); it often refers to “letter magic” in earlier classifications, but later ones typically define it as ‘ilm-i *khayālāt*, “imagination science” or illusionism, following Kāshifī and ‘Alī Ṣafī. See Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One”.

¹⁶Subtelny, “Kāshifī’s *Asrār-i qāsīmī*”.

¹⁷The literature on Benedict Anderson’s wonderfully productive 1983 concept is, ironically, far more extensive than that on Islamic Occult Empire as a whole, which by definition is premised on imagination (*khayāl*) as political and indeed military technology – whence *Boon for the Khan*.

Boozing and Battling as Platonic-Alexandrian Philosopher-Kingship

In its Modernising of the Ancients, *Boon for the Khan* is simultaneously classically pseudo-Platonic and unmistakably Timurid. ‘Alī Ṣafī follows his father to draw in the first place on the famed thirteenth-century alchemist Abū l-Qāsim al-‘Irāqī “the Illusionist” (al-Sīmāwī)’s *Choicest Realities and Their Operations* (‘*Uyūn al-ḥaqā’iq wa-īdāḥ al-ṭarā’iq*) – a semi-esoteric compendium of astral, natural, illusionist and trickery magic – as well as *Eyes’ Ensorcelling* (*Siḥr al-‘uyūn*) by one Abū ‘Abd Allāh al-Maghribī, aka Ibn al-Ḥājj (possibly to be identified with the North African occultist Muḥammad Ibn al-Ḥājj al-Tilimsānī (d. 1336)), a work not known to survive. ‘Irāqī’s latter-day classic devotes a chapter in turn to the “Laws of Nature” (*Nawāmīs*) attributed to Plato – a constantly evolving and expanding Arabic occult pseudepigraphal tradition that also entered partially into Latin under the calque title *Liber Anagumensis* (among others), likely prompted by its listing in the *Goal of the Sage* (*Ghāyat al-ḥakīm*, Lat. *Picatrix*).¹⁸ The operations selected in these three witnesses prefigure in their eclecticism those of *Qasimian Secrets*, though Kāshifī’s selection is more comprehensive and specific as to its sources. Weirdly not included is the grammarian-grimoirist Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī’s (d. 1229) *Comprehensive Book for the Complete and Perfected Man* (*Kitāb al-Shāmil wa-baḥr al-kāmil*) – that watershed magic manual composed under Mongol auspices – of which Kāshifī was well aware but does not use as a source here, despite its similar Arabo-Persianate texture and political-military relevance.¹⁹

But it is only in the long fifteenth century that these grimoires came to be incorporated into a coherent system constructed for Timurid imperial purposes, inherited by, elaborated upon and more systematically deployed by the Safavids, Ottomans, Indo-Timurids (Mughals) and other competing Persianate polities in turn. Here Ibn Turka of Isfahan (d. 1432) emerges as not only the most influential occult philosopher of the Timurid era but among its most influential political philosophers too: with Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī Yazdī (d. 1454), preeminent historian, lettrist and mathematician, and his best friend, he created the astrological-lettrist platform that was to define Persianate imperial cosmology for the next several centuries. To the same end, he is also

¹⁸ Lucia Raggetti, “Hallucinations and Smoke Screens: The Pseudo-Platonic ‘Laws of Nature’ (*Nawāmīs*) and Their Transmission”, *Quaderni di Studi Arabi* 18 (2023): 354–95; Liana Saif, “The Cows and the Bees: Arabic Sources and Parallels for Pseudo-Plato’s *Liber Vaccae* (*Kitāb al-Nawāmīs*)”, *Journal of the Warburg and Courtauld Institute* 79 (2016): 1–48. I translate *nawāmīs* as “rites” below to better convey their early modern usage.

¹⁹ Specifically, in his equally magisterially synthesising Persian *Jewels of Exegesis* (*Javāhir al-tafsīr*) – the first and only known tafsīr to be exclusively lettrist and hence occult – Kāshifī refers at least twice to Sakkākī’s famed and comprehensive grammar, *Key to All Knowledge* (*Miftāḥ al-‘ulūm*), together with the commentaries of Qazvinī and Taftāzānī, on two fine points of rhetoric, and at least once to his *Shāmil* as twin to its eleventh-century predecessor, the *Kitāb al-Shāmil fi l-baḥr al-kāmil* of Ṭabasī (d. 1089). By dubbing them simply the *Shāmilayn*, Kāshifī constructs a continuous grimoiric tradition. My thanks to Emily Selove for this observation; see the forthcoming four-volume edition, translation and edited studies of Sakkākī’s *Shāmil* as part of her Leverhulme-funded “Sorcerer’s Handbook” project, as well as Emily Selove and Mohammed Sayyaf Sanad, “The Sorcerer Scholar: Sirāj al-Dīn al-Sakkākī between Grammar and Grimoire”, in *Inscribing Knowledge and Power in Islamic Societies: Diachronic Studies*, ed. Emily Selove et al. (forthcoming); Travis Zadeh, “Commanding Demons and Jinn: The Sorcerer in Early Islamic Thought”, in *No Tapping around Philology: A Festschrift in Honor of Wheeler McIntosh Thackson Jr.’s 70th Birthday*, ed. Alireza Korangy and Daniel J. Sheffield (Wiesbaden: Harrasowitz, 2014), pp. 131–60; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Reading, Then Rewriting, the Cosmic Text: Kāshifī’s *Jewels of Exegesis* and the Timurid Canonization of Tafsīr as Magic”, in *Esotericism and the Qur’an/L’ésotericisme et le Coran*, ed. Wissam Halawi and Bruce Fudge (forthcoming, 2025). That Kāshifī may not have had direct access to Sakkākī’s grimoire at the time of writing is suggested by the fact that *Boon for the Khan* appears to share with it only one operation via a mutual source, treasure-dowsing by white cock (the first operation in section 1.9 below); close study of *Qasimian Secrets* will be necessary to determine any other overlaps.

the first author in the ancient and venerable debate (*munāẓara*) genre to theorise the warlord state in explicitly occult-scientific, lettrist terms: Boozing and Battling (*bazm u razm*) as the Yin-Yang of Platonic-Pythagorean Empire, whereby the Court is by cosmic definition Occult.²⁰

Inspired by Ibn Turka and his equally imamophile Occult Court, ‘Alī Ṣafī the Sunni Sufi sought to transform Twelver Turko-Mongol warlords into philosopher-kings by means of Plato’s Alexandrian magic. Yet *Boon for the Khan* is singlemindedly devoted to boozing and battling in a way no known previous grimoire had been. This includes Kāshifī’s *Qasimian Secrets*, its immediate source, which presents a panoply of classic operations – many of whose ingredients are encoded by the Kashifian Cipher and unprocurable to boot – relevant to a wide range of social and political contexts. By contrast, ‘Alī Ṣafī extracts, decodes, simplifies and localises only those operations he judges will fit Qizilbash military culture. He even changes the basic mechanics of some to ensure their immediate practicability. For all its brevity and simplicity, *Boon for the Khan* is not simply a minor if fascinating entry in the history of Western occultism, then, but a crucial source for the sociology of the Safavid state at its inception, and a handy taxonomy of boozing and battling culture in early modern Persianate societies more generally.²¹

That this culture was a coherent and robust one is testified to by the dual-purpose nature of many of the operations ‘Alī Ṣafī selected as most definitive of contemporary *bazm* (boozing, feasting, partying and party entertainment) and *razm* (battling, warring, campaigning and hunting), respectively. Thus magic cocaine is of obvious utility in both orgy and war; making someone tell you all their dirty secrets while asleep can be a hilarious party trick or serious interrogation tech; disappearing ink is both fun for party invitations and key in intelligence communications. Ink magic aside, most of the trickery operations are indeed tricks only and meant to entertain and gobsmack guests and create a general atmosphere of wonder. Yet insta-logs, ice-candles and bird-hunting and fishing magic would presumably be of greater use on campaign than at home, unlike, say, fart lamps – though even those could do much to keep up soldier morale!

But many operations are more exclusive to play or to war. Tree-hugging magic has no military application I’m aware of; creating giant flying soldiers and armies of smoke explicitly does. The opening emphasis on pseudo-Platonic sacrificial golems as a source of strength, healing and defence against fire, water and hunger, together with hunting prowess, could not be more military, despite their domestic medical applications

²⁰Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Imperial Talismanic Love: Ibn Turka’s *Debate of Feast and Fight* (1426) as Philosophical Romance and Lettrist Mirror for Timurid Princes”, *Der Islam* 96/1 (2019): 42–86. On cognate developments in the Mediterranean zone, see Cornell H. Fleischer, “A Mediterranean Apocalypse: Prophecies of Empire in the Fifteenth and Sixteenth Centuries”, *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 61 (2018): 18–90.

²¹Like sensationalist reports of their cannibalism, our grimoire thus corroborates “the highly corporeal nature of Qizilbash religious imagination”, inseparable from their military-technological one; see Shahzad Bashir, “Shah Isma‘il and the Qizilbash: Cannibalism in the Religious History of Early Safavid Iran”, *History of Religions* 45/3 (2006): 234–56, p. 235. On Redhead fighting culture, quite successfully anarchic, see Giorgio Rota, “Fighting with the Qizilbash: Preliminary Remarks on Safavid Warfare”, in *Nomad Military Power in Iran and Adjacent Areas in the Islamic Period*, ed. Kurt Franz and Wolfgang Holzwarth (Wiesbaden: Reichert, 2015), pp. 233–46. While *Boon for the Khan* cannot be said to condone cannibalism (the human bones it prescribes are not for human but rather tree consumption), an argument can easily be made for magic as anarchy – and hence for boozing and battling magic as not just democratic but overtly anarchic.

too. (Funding for war tech has historically funded peace tech as a rule, especially today.) At the same time, what might seem to the modern reader to be frivolous operations are designed to be therapeutic for their audience, a conscious harnessing of the experimentally proven principle of laughter as medicine (see again the fart lamp).

All the illusions and tricks in *Boon for the Khan*, whether for boozing or for battling, tonically hilarious or dead serious, embody the culture of wonder (*taʿajjub*), the ethos of the weird (*gharīb*), that defines Persianate early modern philosophy and science, poetry and painting, ethics and politics generally, and the occult sciences (*ʿulūm-i gharība*) in particular.²² Yet ʿAlī Ṣafī’s choice of operations, albeit mostly of pseudo-ancient pedigree, is curiously “Enlightened”: he explicitly excludes such exotic if perennially reported phenomena as flying, instantaneous travel, invisibility and shapeshifting as beyond reason, which is to say scientifically unprovable or technologically impracticable. This smacks of the position of modern parapsychology, which as an academic discipline necessarily limits itself to the study of those effects that can be reproduced under controlled or laboratory conditions, rather than the chaos of orgy or war, when paranormality tends to flourish: for trauma and high weirdness are twins.²³ But in this, his grimoire for pragmatic, anarchic Qizilbash warlords, ʿAlī Ṣafī rationalises and modernises Plato’s instruction to Alexander on both fronts: there can be no empire without fighting and feasting, Mars and Venus, war and peace – and the best technologies of empire are empirical and occult.

Democratic Magic as Imperial Early Modernity

The de-esotericisation and democratisation of occultism – a defining theme of Afro-Eurasian early modernities – is emblematised by the very pennames of Ḥusayn the Preacher and his son and successor ʿAlī. *Kāshifī* means something like “Agent of the Unveiler”; *Ṣafī* means “the Pure”. Designedly generic, though of strong Sufi resonance, the first signals its author’s devotion to the canonisation and popularisation of all fields of knowledge for a pan-Persianate audience.²⁴ But the second is unequivocally Timurid: it signals ʿAlī’s commitment to lettrism (*ʿilm-i ḥurūf*) as master Pythagorean occult science as developed by Ibn Turka and his New Brethren of Purity, who identified

²²Travis Zadeh, *Wonders and Rarities: The Marvelous Book That Traveled the World and Mapped the Cosmos* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2023); Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “An Islamic Scientific Revolution? Early Modern Occult Science, Cosmic Philology and the Weird”, ed. Justin Stearns and Nahyan Fancy, special roundtable issue, *History of Science* 61/2 (2023): 166–72; *idem*, “Translating Esotericism: Early Modern Persian”, in *Translating Esotericism*, ed. Wouter J. Hanegraaff and Mriganka Mukhopadhyay, special issue, *Correspondences* 11/2 (2023): 103–12.

²³Erik Davis, *High Weirdness: Drugs, Esoterica and Visionary Experience in the Seventies* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2019); Dean Radin, *Real Magic: Ancient Wisdom, Modern Science, and a Guide to the Secret Power of the Universe* (New York: Harmony Books, 2018).

²⁴Per Subtelny’s hypothesis (“*Kāshifī’s Asrār-i qāsimī*”), the penname of the posthumous dedicatee of *Qasimian Secrets*, the influential, charismatic and dangerously populist Herati Niʿmatallāhi Sufi master Jalāl al-Dīn ʿAlī b. Naṣīr, famed as Qāsim-i Anvār (d. 1434) – one of Ibn Turka’s companions in Cairo, and like him cancelled and exiled in 1427 for his lettrist associations – translates as “Distributor of Lights”, and is thus of a de-esotericising tenor too. The very title *Qasimian Secrets*, or literally translated *Secrets of the Distributor*, plays on the esoteric/exoteric tension that defines so much of Western intellectual and sociopolitical history – only to plump for democratisation. Here the fact that one of the copies of *Boon for the Khan* on which my translation below relies (Tehran, Majlis MS 1065/5) immediately invokes the divine name *Qāsim* is significant: by virtue of the standard Arabo-Persian rhetorical device of *barāʾat-i istiḥlāl*, this witness (probably seventeenth-century) would seem to corroborate Subtelny’s hypothesis; see n. 36 below.

precisely with the democratisation of Pythagorean occultism carried out by the original *Ikhwān al-ṣafāʾ* in a similarly synthesising and encyclopaedic mode.²⁵

An informal intellectual network of eminent and influential scholars spanning from the Mughal Empire to the Ottoman by the second half of the sixteenth century, the New Brethren were born in Mamluk Cairo around the turn of the fifteenth, which cosmopolitan capital served as central alembic for the experimental testing of new forms of occult-philosopher kingship and court ritual in the Platonic-Alexandrian mode.²⁶ That this specifically Cairene ethos helped drive, ironically, the Ottoman conquest of the Mamluk Sultanate, then set the terms of Persianate (including Ottoman) imperial rivalry through at least the mid-seventeenth century, suggests it as a crucial node for comparative early modern historiography.²⁷

As a case in point: it is this shared Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu-Safavid-Ottoman-Uzbek-Mughal court culture that inspired the creation of the watershed Persian encyclopaedia *The Stars That Are the Sciences* (*Nujūm al-ʿulūm*) – the most extensively and gorgeously illustrated of all early modern Persian books, and almost exclusively imperial and occult – by the Deccan Twelver sultan ʿAlī ʿĀdilshāh (r. 1558–1579), with innovative emphasis on magic war tech; its total, astral-scientific marriage of Greece and India, Persian and Sanskrit, West and East, helped inspire the ʿĀdilshahis’ Mughal foes to do the same in turn.²⁸

Similarly, ʿAlī Ṣafī (true to his name and penname) goes beyond his sources to make explicit what they leave implicit and transcend the contemporary political binary, marrying the Ancient-Modern and Timurid-Safavid opposites in classic Pythagorean-lettrist fashion. In a paradigm-shifting departure from Ibn Turka’s occult-imperial project, however, more focused on the direct transformation of Turko-Mongol warlords into occult philosopher-kings, in his bestselling *Amulet of Protection* he insists rather on something we might anachronistically call “occult democracy”: the empowering of state bureaucrats and scholars and their urban clients to mind-control tyrannical sovereigns with magic. Here, applied lettrism remains an important technology of empire and personal advancement alike, whether physically or spiritually, and regardless of class; but

²⁵See Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the Renaissance of Pythagoreanism in the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis”, *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 13/1 (2025), forthcoming.

²⁶This experimentation was especially pronounced at the court of Sultan al-Malik al-Zāhir Barquq (r. 1382–1399), patron to the original New Brethren; see *ibid.* Several later Mamluk rulers were similarly intellectually, culturally and politically experimentalist, particularly the penultimate sultan, Qāniṣawh al-Ghawrī, though with less emphasis on the occult sciences as political technologies; see Christian Mauder, *In the Sultan’s Salon: Learning, Religion and Rulership at the Mamluk Court of Qāniṣawh al-Ghawrī (r. 1501–1516)*, volumes I–II (Leiden: Brill, 2021). On the strong Persianate presence in Mamluk court culture, see *idem*, “Being Persian in Late Mamluk Egypt: The Construction and Significance of Persian Ethnic Identity in the Salons of Sultan Qāniṣawh al-Ghawrī (r. 906–922/1501–1516)”, *Al-ʿUṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 28 (2020): 376–408.

²⁷Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Toward a Neopythagorean Historiography: Kemālpāzādē’s (d. 1534) Lettrist Call for the Conquest of Cairo and the Development of Ottoman Occult-Scientific Imperialism”, in *Islamic Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice*, ed. Liana Saif, Francesca Leoni, Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Farouk Yahya (Leiden: Brill, 2021), pp. 380–419.

²⁸The *Nujūm al-ʿulūm* is brilliantly studied in this volume and elsewhere by Emma Flatt; see especially her *Courtly Pursuits: Living Well in the Deccan Sultanates* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019). Significantly, Sakkāki (and/or his son) is also a major source; see Travis Zadeh, “Postscript: Cutting Ariadne’s Thread, or How to Think Otherwise in the Maze”, in *Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice*, ed. Liana Saif, Francesca Leon, Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Farouk Yahya (Leiden: Brill, 2021), pp. 607–50, esp. 634–6. On the epochal Sanskrit-Persian translation movement more generally, see Audrey Truschke, *Culture of Encounters: Sanskrit at the Mughal Court* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2016).

‘Alī Ṣafī’s open call for *magic bureaucracy* as the best solution to tyranny is to my knowledge unprecedented and unparalleled in the grimoire genre. As he states in the preface:

In its composition [this treatise] constitutes a summary of and selections from the most authoritative and esteemed works on the subject now in common circulation, and for all its summariness should be of such comprehensive usefulness as to furnish all people, elite and commoner alike, the means to achieve both worldly and otherworldly ends, felicity both physical and spiritual. But it will be of the most use to the great and the powerful (*arbāb-i jāh u muknat*). Those who hold high office may thereby increase their glory and rank, and mastery of most such noble operations is particularly incumbent on courtiers and deputies of kings, responsible for the capable and intelligent legal and financial administration of realms. For among the operations this treatise discusses are those that enable the realisation of [every possible] hope or aim: promotion to higher office and rank, psychic control of tyrants and persuasiveness with rulers, destruction of the enemies of religion and state and conquest of the foes of kingdom and community, attainment of victory and success²⁹

Boon for the Khan, by contrast, Ṣimāwian and Sakkākian rather than Būnian, ensures that its less-educated warlord readers can do magic too. Taken as a whole, ‘Alī Ṣafī’s oeuvre thus embodies the same marriage of adaptive, experientialist innovation and respect for tradition, *taḥqīq* and *taqlīd*, Science and Religion, State and Society, that flags it as peculiarly early modern.³⁰ The short poem he here put into his patron’s mouth epitomises Afro-Eurasian democratising early modernities:

The door to Mercy’s treasury, long locked by Wisdom’s seal,
in our glorious day has been opened wide!
Eternity’s stored wine, however pure,
only becomes purer poured in our hearts’ cups –
So has the Beloved’s gospel come to being’s bazaar:
the Resurrection long awaited is here!

To be sure, ‘Alī Ṣafī’s claim to present these occult-political sciences “without obscuration, the veils of these virginal brides stripped away” seems to reprise standard medieval Persian tropes; indeed, virgin veil removal had long since become a stock metaphor for the act of writing itself. His invocation of Resurrection (*qiyāmat*) through publishing the secrets of the ancients likewise rhymes well with contemporary western European claims to Renaissance – though minus, of course, the Eurocentric, xenophobic chauvinism and anti-Arabism that marred the Latin humanist movement and made much of its science retrograde.³¹

Yet *Boon for the Khan* and his other works depart structurally from their classical and even modern sources (like *Qasimian Secrets* often still encoded) to deliver materially on

²⁹Alī Safī, *Ḥirz al-amān*, MS 15708, fols. 2b–3a, and MS 12503, fo;s. 1b–2a, Majlis Library, Tehran. A number of more private aims follow: “ennoblement of character, knowledge of the various occult sciences, attraction of blessings and all manner of good, attainment of felicity and purpose, safety when traveling or at home from every stripe of fear or danger, security against poverty and need, protection of possessions and children and wives, prevention of plague and disease, safety from harm by hand of jinn or human and freedom from all forms of restriction and incarceration.”

³⁰Melvin-Koushki, “*Tahqīq vs. Taqlīd*”.

³¹Dag Nikolaus Hasse, *Success and Suppression: Arabic Sciences and Philosophy in the Renaissance* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2016). Cf. Shaykh Badr al-Dīn (Bedreddin) of Simavna (executed 1420) – infamous ideologue behind the most successful rebellion in early Ottoman history – and his similarly Akbarian declaration of a utopian Apocalypse Now with lettrist overtones: Fleischer, “Mediterranean Apocalypse”, 42, 47; Melvin-Koushki, “Neopythagorean Historiography”, 397.

that promise in an idiom redesigned to be useful to all – especially politically and militarily. By the same token, the preface of this work gives us one of the most succinct but clear Persian definitions of concepts that often go under the Greco-Latinate names of “occultism” and “esotericism” in Modern English, where by reason of still-endemic Eurocentrism they are far more embattled and mostly condemned to “religion”, but popularly loosely connote “magic” and “secrecy” respectively.³² ‘Alī Ṣafī erects a similar magic/secrecy binary – only to collapse and subvert it. Epistemologically supreme – like physics today – the occult sciences are precisely those sciences that give their practitioners empirical access to reality/divinity (*ḥaqq*) itself. This renders them both inherently elite and sociopolitically dangerous, and hence ethically problematic, so in special need of esotericism: think Einstein and the Bomb (with better parties). Having established this rule of venerable Mediterranean antiquity, ‘Alī Ṣafī dedicates his modernising oeuvre to respectfully breaking it.

For the modern historian of democratic persuasion, in sum, *Boon for the Khan* may be profitably read as a Platonic-Alexandrian bomb manual married to a party manual, whose unprecedentedly clear occult instructions were meant to be leaked on the Turko-Mongol Perso-Islamic Sunni-Shi‘i imperial internet. Judging by their bestselling status throughout the Persianate world, which saw the proliferation of occult philosopher-kingship and occult bureaucracy alike, ‘Alī Ṣafī and his father Ḥusayn Kāshifi’s leaking campaign was a wonder-inducing win for “occult democracy”, and helped establish the Occult Court as a mainstream institution across early modern Islamo-Afro-Eurasia.

Note on the Text

Boon for the Khan is preserved in at least 12 known manuscripts, seven of which survive in Iran and the rest in India, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan and England; the earliest date to the first half of the seventeenth century, over a hundred years after the text’s composition.³³ (By contrast, *Amulet of Protection* survives in over 80 manuscripts in Iran alone and multiple Indian lithograph editions.) Given the fraught circumstances in which it was written, it is unsurprising that these later witnesses display an unusual degree of textual divergence between copies. Most have lacunae or lack folios, and even the most complete are confused as to the mechanics of certain operations or their ingredient lists. I have philologically addressed such issues by referring to its much better-preserved source, *Qasimian Secrets* (also boasting over 80 manuscript copies and multiple Indian lithograph editions), and through comparison with the five extant manuscripts at my disposal.

My translation below thus depends on the earliest surviving dated manuscript, copied by Mullā Bābā-Jān Ṭāliqānī on 15 Ramaḍān 1049 (9 January 1640), and preserved in Tehran as Majlis MS 12575/2 (see [Figure 1](#) below). While mostly complete, it is fairly

³²Melvin-Koushki, “Translating Esotericism”.

³³See Dirāyatī, *Faṅkha*, 7/405–6; Storey, *Persian Literature*, 2/460. The other manuscript copies known to me are Kolkata, Kitābkhāna-yi Idāra-yi Āsiyā‘ī-yi Bangāl, MS 530, 14 ff. (copied 1223/1808 by Muḥammad ‘Alī Bāqir); Ahmādābad, Kitābkhāna-yi Dargāh-i Pīr-Muḥammad Shāh, MS 1763/A, 24 ff. (copied 1247/1831); Tashkent, Kitābkhāna-yi Bunyād-i Khāvarshināsiyi Farhangistān-i ‘Ulūm, MS 2621 (Ḥamid Sulaymān) (copied 1253/1837); Dushanbe, Kitābkhāna-yi Ārshiv-i Simyūnūv, MS 108/2.

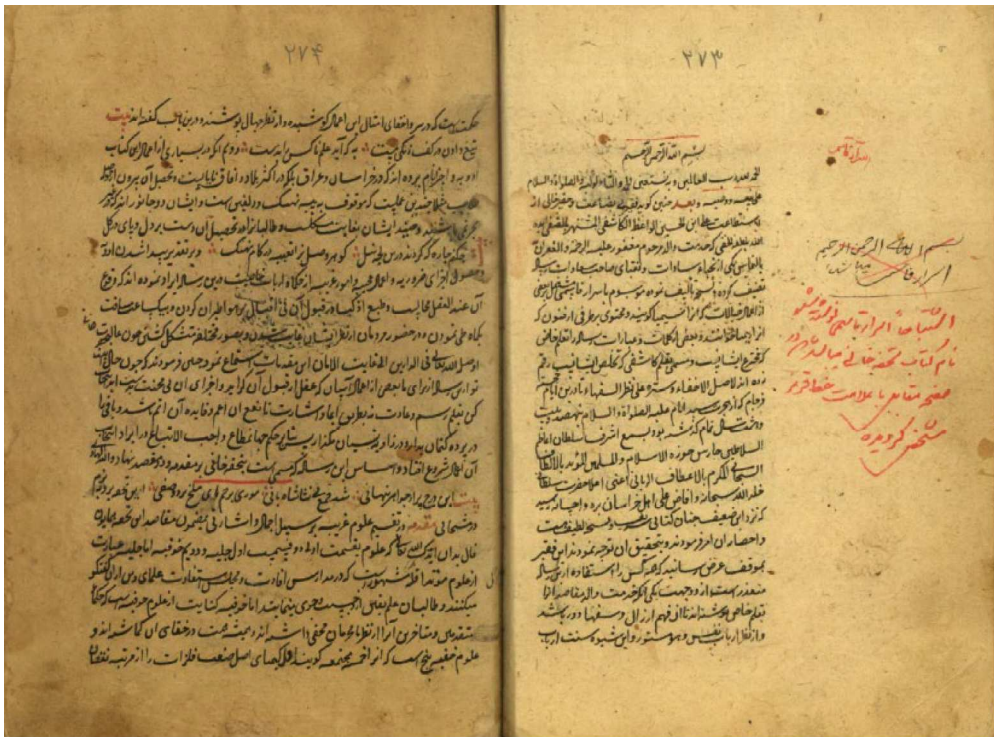


Figure 1. Opening pages of *Tuḥfa-yi khāni* (mistitled *Asrār-i Qāsimi* per marginal note in red), Tehran, Majlis Library, MS 12575/2 (copied 1640), pp. 273–84.

messy and often unreliable; the copyist (clearly not an occult specialist) has reduced many passages and technical instructions to gibberish. To correct them, I had recourse in the first place to Qom, Masjid-i A'zam, MS 3432/2, which despite missing folios at the beginning and end preserves the most reliable and elegant text – clearly the version experienced by Safavid scholars at the turn of the seventeenth century, when *Qasimian Secrets* was expanded into a who's who of courtly occult culture.³⁴ Where certain passages and ingredients remained unclear, I consulted Tehran, Majlis MS 1065/5 (17th c.); Qom, Gulpāyagānī MS 35/4 (copied 1112/1700); Oxford, Bodleian MS 2749 (Pers D. 100) (copied 1100/1689); and the earliest copies of *Qasimian Secrets* itself.³⁵ Since the earliest *Boon for the Khan* manuscripts drop or are missing the last three sections of the text, on water, writing and bird-hunting and fishing trickery, I have dropped them in my translation too, to reflect the likelihood, based on the surviving record, that the author's political circumstances prevented him from completing his grimoire's 2-12 structure as intended in 1522, hence the later confusion; readers interested in these operations may refer to the author's father's original.³⁶

³⁴Subtelny, "Kāshifi's *Asrār-i qāsimi*".

³⁵Epitomising this confusion, one nineteenth-century copy (Qom, Gulpāyagānī MS 183/26) appends the introduction of the *Tuḥfa-yi khāni* to a random selection of sections from the *Asrār-i Qāsimi*.

³⁶The MS Gulpāyagānī 35 and otherwise fairly reliable MS Bodleian 2749 copies include all three sections in full. Given the frequent unreliability of the former (many operations are dropped or rendered gibberish), and the frequent illegibility of the latter in the Tehran University microfilm scan to which I have access, I cannot yet determine the probability of

‘Alī Ṣafī’s circumstances aside, such philological confusion is endemic to the pseudo-Platonic genre he engages; pharmacological ingredient lists are the most susceptible to textual corruption or change over time and space and language, making many ancient and medieval operations almost impossible to reproduce. A case in point is his simple recipe for magic cocaine, variations on which (for obvious reasons) have been popular since antiquity: even the identity of its active ingredient, *ḥabb al-nīl*, Nile Seed – most likely blue water lily or beach morning glory seeds, given their psychoactive effects and possible availability in early sixteenth-century Khurasan – cannot be determined without personal experimentation due to textual corruption and philological confusion over the centuries.³⁷ (One of the manuscripts even mistakes it as *ḥabb al-fīl*, Elephant Seed, apparently referring to a type of Indian watercress not known to be psychoactive.)

Durmish Khān’s frustration is more than understandable in this long-confused pharmacological-textual context – hence his insistence on ingredients that can be clearly identified and reliably locally sourced. While *Boon for the Khan* was similarly subject to the vicissitudes of textual reception during a traumatic, transitional time, it is a successful answer to that charge: its ancient and modern recipes are so closely curated as to be potentially reproducible by persophone readers today, warlord and civilian alike.

My translation below attempts to convey both the content and the texture of ‘Alī Ṣafī’s text to an anglophone audience by treating Persian as English and Arabic as Latin, since by accident of historical and imperial evolution New Persian and Modern English structurally mirror each other quite precisely. Where natural, I therefore vernacularise explanatory ingredient terms and other glosses, and leave a few problematic Arabic words untranslated, in modern imitation of our early modern democratising grimoire.

Boon for the Khan

In the name of God, All-Merciful, Ever-Merciful

Praise be to God, Lord of all the worlds, Whose succour we seek. All praise be to His Saint, and all prayers and blessings be upon His Prophet and his Legatee.³⁸

To proceed: Says the poor and hapless wretch ‘Alī son of Ḥusayn Kāshifī the Preacher, known as Ṣafī (God aid him with His occult grace): My departed father (upon whom be mercy and forgiveness) at the request of an eminent and felicitated lord penned a treatise entitled *Qasimian Secrets*, comprising various illusionist operations termed *ṣimiyā* and a sampling of [tricks] known as *rīmiyā*. He encoded certain key terms and phrases in that

these sections being later additions; but the fact that in both manuscripts the last section on bird-hunting and fishing trickery is oddly far longer than any other in the *Tuhfa*, with ten operations to the usual two or three, does suggest them as such. The similarly unreliable and likely later MS Majlis 1065 copy includes part of the penultimate section on writing trickery (egg writing and fire writing), then closes abruptly. Happily, the copies in India, Uzbekistan and Tajikistan promise to solve this philological problem.

³⁷My thanks to Nicholas Harris for his alchemical, pharmacological and philological brilliance on this point. His suggested translation of this recipe as “magic smelling salts” is likewise more technically accurate; I translate it here as “magic cocaine” instead to convey the warlord context for its use. More generally, following Raggetti, this offering is intended to help frame *Boon for the Khan* “in the social context in which these practices were embedded and to [help] pin down the performative component that many of them implied”, while exploring “the technical and material reality behind the text” (“Hallucinations and Smoke Screens”, 354).

³⁸This, the opening in the MS Majlis 12575 copy, goes well beyond the bounds of normal imamophilia to seemingly invoke Imam ‘Alī before the Prophet himself. The MS Majlis 1065 copy alternate is more sedate: “The Distributor (*Qāsim*) of gifts and Knower of boons – to Him be praise mornings and evenings for His infinite aid, and blessings and peace be upon Muḥammad – holy Lord of Lords and Beloved welcomed by all – and all his House.”

treatise with a cipher, however, and one of his own invention – hence its appellation “Cipher of the Unveiler” (*qalam-i Kāshifi*) – after the esotericist manner, to veil it from the consideration of fools.³⁹ In these auspicious days, 928 years after the emigration of the Lord of Humanity (blessings and peace be upon him), my possession of this noble and subtle work came to the attention of the most noble and greatest of all sultans, guardian of the domain of Islam and all Muslims and divinely guided and graced – the most eminent Sultan himself (God make perduring his reign and shower Khurasan’s people with his goodness and charity) – who thereupon requested that it be brought to him for rigorous study.

My lord then asked this wretch to make it comprehensible and useful to everyone, given its difficulty of use in two respects. First, my father’s purpose in employing his cipher was precisely to make it inaccessible to ignoble and foolish people, those consumed by ego and base desire, after the custom of all sages, who have always hidden the secrets of such operations from the ignorant. As it has been sung:

Better give a sword to a slave in his cups
than knowledge to the unworthy!⁴⁰

Second, many of the operations in this book prescribe potions and ingredients impossible to make or find in Khurasan or [Persian] Iraq, and indeed most lands, and so are beyond the reach of most users. For example, shark or dolphin fat is called for in several operations; yet both are sea creatures extremely difficult to procure inland, so can only frustrate would-be users to no end.⁴¹

What can I do – they’ve thrown the pearl that is union with you
into the depths of the Nile and a crocodile’s belly!⁴²

Even if the necessary ingredients can be procured, moreover, the weird and wondrous effects of these operations – like flying, instantaneous travel, invisibility and shapeshifting, as cited here from leading authorities and sages of the natural sciences – can still provoke their rejection as beyond reason or simply impossible.

Having considered these impediments, the Khan (God preserve him wholly in both worlds) ordered me to extract for him certain simple operations to which reason cannot object and whose ingredients can be sourced without difficulty, then formulate them as clearly and accessibly as possible with no obfuscation so everyone can benefit, leaving the rest safely hidden. Obedience to the world-commanding Lord’s command being requisite, I undertook such an extraction, resulting in the present treatise, which I have named *Boon for the Khan*. It comprises an introduction and two sections – but God alone is the Guide.

This jewelbox hides many gems
collected to present to the perduring king:
As the ant approaches Jamshīd on grasshopper feet
does Ṣafī bear this boon to Durmish Khān’s banquet!

³⁹An ironic play on Kāshifi’s penname.

⁴⁰Mawlāwī (Rūmī), *Maṣnavī-yi ma’navī*, Book 4, 35.2.

⁴¹Lit., making them put “hand to the heart but foot in the mud”.

⁴²Jāmī, ghazal: *az dar-i basta u dīvār-i buland-i tū bi tang*.

Introduction

On a general definition of the occult sciences (*‘ulūm-i gharība*) and the objectives of this royal boon:

Know (God Most High help you) that the sciences are in the first place classed into two categories: manifest (*jaliyya*) and occult (*khafiyya*). The manifest sciences are those popularly known and commonly pursued in collegial and scholarly contexts, and much discoursed upon by all students of apodictic and scholastic knowledge. [By contrast], “occult” refers to the sciences that deal with reality itself (*‘ulūm-i haqqiyya*), [so powerful and elite] that ancient and modern scholars alike have endeavoured to occult (*makhfī*) them from the unworthy – and continue to be devoted to the same end. Among the occult sciences is a group famed as the Occult Quintet:

kīmiyā (alchemy), whose adepts elevate base metals to their perfection as silver or gold;
limiyā (talismanry), devices that conjunct active celestial forces with passive terrestrial ones to produce effects weird and wondrous;

hīmiyā (subjugation), the persuasion of planets and inclining of jinn through rigorous ritual, amuletic or invocatory practice;

sīmiyā (illusionism), in some operations leveraging such influence on the imaginal faculty of observers that gossamer images that are clearly unreal appear before their eyes;

rīmiyā (trickery), whose specialists mix various terrestrial substances to produce new, active powers that amaze and astound.

The most eminent sages have written many celebrated treatises and foundational books on these five sciences, some of which are cited in my father’s *Qasimian Secrets*. Its focus, however, is on the latter two, illusionism and trickery, to each of which he devoted a full section with numerous subsections. This wretch has therefore extracted from these two sections operations easy to understand and perform, comprising 12 per section. They are presented here without obscuration, the veils of these virginal brides stripped away – this at the instance of his holy eminence the Khan, who commanded that these hidden secrets be revealed here, singing these auspicious verses:

The door to Mercy’s treasury, long locked by Wisdom’s seal,
 in our glorious day has been opened wide!
 Eternity’s stored wine, however pure,
 only becomes purer poured in our hearts’ cups –
 So has the Beloved’s gospel come to being’s bazaar:
 the Resurrection long awaited is here!

Section One: Illusionism

On certain operations produced by illusionism, comprising 12 sections:

1. Putrefactions of the Greater Rite
2. Suffumigations of the Greater Rite
3. Putrefactions of the Lesser Rite
4. Suffumigations of the Lesser Rite

5. Food rite
6. Drink rite
7. Wake-up rite
8. Sleeper interrogation
9. Treasure dowsing
10. Predator subjugation
11. Instant agriculture
12. Kohl-vision

1. Putrefactions of the Greater Rite

In specialists' technical usage, illusionist operations are referred to as rites (sg. *nāmūs*). The most impressive disciplines in illusionism are called the Greater Rite, its disciplines therefore being divided into the Greater and Lesser Rites. Both comprise a great number of operations, of which putrefactions (*ta'fināt*) constitute a substantial fraction.

Here, an easy operation should be mentioned: Take a leaf of lettuce and soak it in camel blood, then bury it in dung. Once it begins excreting moisture and its surface becomes firm, replace the dung every three days, continuing this process until it is putrefied and spirit becomes attached; a few days later it will birth an animal with the form of a snake but a head like a camel's, with two black eyes and two small wings growing out of its shoulders. Whenever you wish to open the container, the snake will open its eyes, upon which immediately drip one or two drops of camel blood. Drip them into its mouth and body too, and it will voraciously consume the drops; this will continue for three days. Then, according to its period, give it instead 40 drams of male camel lung, which it will immediately eat, feeding it like this for four days. When seven days have thus elapsed from its birth, it will swell in the container and coil into a circle. Then drip male camel urine on it, and it will immediately stand up and start moving, though weakly. Seal the container lid for three hours to let it mature; when you open it again its movements therein will be much quicker. Then apply a knife to it, pressing until blood begins to boil out and pool in the container; whatever property it has is in that blood. Throughout the process of raising it, great care must be taken that the container lid be firmly sealed lest it escape, and any failure to follow these directions precisely will result in the failure of the operation.

Leading sages among those who have mastered this operation further report that this blood applied to the soles of your feet allows you to walk through fire without them being burned, and generally acts as a fire repellent. Light will also spark under you as you walk and you won't tire however far you travel, and you will travel much faster than usual. The same property applies to water: it prevents your feet from sinking. Yet applied to hands lifted in prayer to God Most High for rain, it will indeed rain, even out of season. Wiped on your face, it becomes invisible to the eyes of men. This blood can also reanimate corpses, as well as heal leprous flesh, by leave of God Most High.

2. Suffumigations of the Greater Rite

Suffumigation (*tadhkhīn*) operations are patently much easier than putrefaction ones; here two of the easiest will be mentioned.

The first is Men of Smoke, whereby one burns small balls like peppercorns on a cloudy day – properly arranged on the fire, its smoke will look to everyone like [gigantic] men with their feet on the ground and their heads in the clouds. This is the operation: Take an equal ten parts of lead oxide, astringent, verdigris, gold dross, red arsenic, burnt copper, red lead and dried blood from the barbers and five equal parts of Persian buttercup (*kabīkaj*) and mulberry wood and cook them all together; sift the result and combine with fish fat and mulberry juice to make a paste, then fashion into small balls the size of peppercorns and dry in the shade. When you wish to perform the operation, on a very cloudy day and in an elevated place build a fire with cow dung and wait for the flames to die down, then put the balls in the fire – and they will produce wonders!

The second is Riders of Smoke, whereby one burns small balls 30 drams [or one ounce] in weight to produce smoke, which will appear to everyone as a [gigantic] horse and rider galloping between heaven and earth; with multiple fires a wondrous cavalry can be created. This is known as Plato's Smoke, [from the time] Alexander set off to meet Plato with an innumerable army; when they reached the foot of the mountain in which Plato dwelled and struck camp, Plato decided to manifest his own army to Alexander. He therefore set a fire on the mountain's summit and burned these balls, thereby overwhelming Alexander with his power – until the mighty force came near and its forms disappeared like tracings on water. This is the operation: Take ten drams each of pitch, Indianwood (euphorbia), mercury, dogfish fat, storax and aloes and five grams of gum from the desert wadi tree (well known to Arabs and much used by physicians to treat patients), cooking each separately, except for the mercury, which is drizzled on the other components; the whole is then mixed together with a pound of oil, then made into balls of the weight specified above and dried in the shade. [When you wish to perform the operation], make a fire from red goat droppings, and when the flames have died down [add the balls to] make smoke – and such amazing wonders will be seen in the sky!

3. Putrefactions of the Lesser Rite, comprising one operation:

Take a lentil with the dirt it was planted and sprouted in and cover with human blood obtained from a barber, then put the whole in a reflective container and bury it in horse dung. When it putrefies it will produce a form with a human face but the body of a bird with two wings of dirt. It will not live more than seven days and perhaps die in fewer. When it dies bathe it in pure wax and wine and wrap it in a clean cotton cloth to carry with you – for its properties are wondrous indeed. First: it allows you to travel without needing to stop. Second: it makes large predators (like lions and panthers) so submissive that you may take them by the ears and ride them. [Third]: its bearer feels little hunger or thirst. Its many other properties will likewise manifest to its bearer, though these belong to the realm of protected secrets.

4. Suffumigations of the Lesser Rite, comprising one operation:

This smoke is such that when placed at the base of a tree all its branches bend toward the operator, astonishing all who witness. Take a vulture brain, black snake bone and human

bone and mix them together, then cook the mixture, bury it in damp earth for 40 days, then bring it out and dry it. Mix part of it with part of a very old human bone and cook that. Burn the resulting mixture under any tree you wish, and its branches will immediately bend toward you such that some even touch you, and will remain in this posture as long as the smoke lasts.

5. Food rites, comprising two operations:

The first: Take a gazelle liver, slice it thinly and dry the pieces in the shade, then take the same weight of almond meat and cook them together, adding to the mixture oil of almond blossom until it is fully absorbed, then dry the result and save it. When needed, eat five grams: you won't need food for the next three weeks. However, you won't have much energy, and you can't eat any other kind of food, which could be fatal. If possible, purge your bowels first.

The second, which is simpler than the first: Take a gazelle liver and dry it, then pound it fine like dust. Mix the result with oil of almond blossom until it becomes like dough, then cook with rainwater until firm. When needed, eat a handful, about ten grams: you won't need to eat for a week, though the same conditions apply.

6. Drink rites, comprising one operation:

Take some caraway seed, cleaned of dirt and dust, and boil a measure; remove and pat dry, then mix with pure honey free of wax. When consumed with a measure of large almonds or walnuts, it relieves you of the need for liquids for quite some time.

7. Wake-up rite, comprising two operations:

The first: Kill an owl, observing which of its eyes was open and which closed at the moment of death; cleanly extract the eye that was open and wrap it in a clean cloth and keep it on your person, and you won't sleep. (Some say a monkey's eye has the same property.)

The second: If you want party attendees to stay awake all night, take storax (aka "barbers' rust"), water lily seeds, pigeon dung and castoreum and cook them together, then burn the resulting paste on a coal – its smoke will keep any who inhale it wide awake.

8. Sleeper interrogation, comprising three operations:

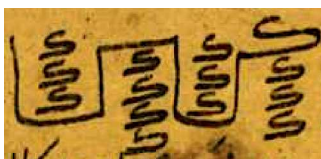
The first: If you wish to extract information from someone while they sleep, take an owl heart and wrap it in a clean cloth, then place it on the sleeper's chest – and by God Most High, they will quickly tell you, while still unconscious, whatever you ask.

The second: Take "wolf cotton" and knead it in your hand, then place it on the sleeper's chest – they will answer any question you ask without waking up.

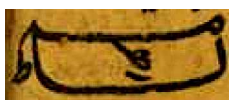
The third: Take the tongue of a giant owl (a bird of prey) and wrap it in a clean cloth, then place it on the sleeper's chest – they will answer any question you ask. (Reportedly this last operation only works on women.)

9. Treasure dowsing, comprising two operations:

The first: As the master Shaykh Ba'lbakkī instructs in his treatise *On the Active Properties of Letters*, take a sheet of silver and etch thereon 14 Ks in a special way shown below, then hang it from an *afraq* white cock's neck (*afraq* meaning one with a multipronged but short comb) and take him to a place you think something might be buried. Dig wherever the cock pecks, for something is likely buried there, whether money or a magical object. The Ks should be etched as follows:



The second: [As another example] of the properties of letters as they interact with other things, take a black cat or a black bird – they must not have a single white hair – and write the following words on a piece of green silk with the blood of a pigeon (domestic, not wild), then hang it from the cat or bird's neck [and repeat the above procedure]. The form of these words is as follows:



10. Predator taming, comprising two operations:

The first: Take the tongue of a black cat and insert it under the sole of your shoe or boot between two pieces of leather, such that it touches neither your foot nor the ground, then ride out on the hunt wearing it – and all predators and beasts will be attracted to you and become tame.

The second: If you wish to prevent all dogs from barking at you and make them submit to you and follow you, take the tongue of a black dog and follow the same procedure, inserting it into your shoe or boot, and the effect will follow.

11. Instant agriculture, comprising one operation:

To plant a seed during a party and have it sprout and grow to the point of giving fruit within the hour, take long black Indian hair and Indian grain and a cucumber seed and cover them with blood from the barbers, then let the mixture cook in the sun for seven days. Put the result on a piece of clean paper and keep it in the dark for seven more days until it becomes firm, then wrap it in a piece of new linen and store it. [In the meantime], take some dung-enriched dirt from a farmer's furrow at ploughing

time and dry and store it too. When the time comes to perform the operation, pile the mixture on the ground or a large plate and plant the seed therein, watering the seed directly with warm water; then cover it with a handkerchief and preoccupy your guests with conversation. After an hour [they will see to their amazement that] the seed has sprouted tall and put out leaves, flowers and fruit – an operation most weird and wondrous!

12. Kohl-vision (applying collyrium to the eyes to see wonders), comprising two operations:

The first: To see jinn, take some ant eggs and the brain of a green vulture and pulverise, then apply the powder to your eyes – and you will see jinn.

The second: To see wonders, combine lizard venom (or in some manuscripts, black lizard blood)⁴³ with cock blood and dry the mixture, then pulverise and apply to your eyes like kohl – and you will see many wonders invisible to others, both jinn and other denizens of the realm Unseen.

Section Two: Trickery

On *rīmiyā* or trickery, comprising 12 sections:

1. Wick wonders
2. Lamp wonders
3. Candle wonders
4. Ring wonders
5. Glass wonders
6. Figurine wonders
7. Cup wonders
8. Egg wonders
9. Fireplay
10. Waterplay
11. Writing wonders
12. Bird-hunting and fishing

1. Wick wonders, comprising three operations:

The first is the Yellow Wick, which when lighted makes all present appear bilious and ugly to the point they find each other repulsive. This operation was invented when someone requested of a Greek sage as follows: “I have a son and daughter who are twins, and both very attractive; they have fallen in love with each other and are behaving very indecently in public. If they keep on like this and go so far as to have sex, I fear they will ruin my reputation. Please give me a cure!” Having contemplated the matter at great length, the sage finally came up with this operation: “Light this wick and have them both sit in its glow – they will be so repulsed by each other as to destroy their love completely, to the point that they will run in opposite directions and never associate with each other

⁴³This parenthesis in the text shows our copyist to have been working from several sources to create an experimentally reliable manual.

again. Take a piece of old cotton and wind it very firmly and thickly around some white metal filings, then place it in a new lamp and fill with clear oil: those who sit in its glow will turn yellow and their teeth turn black, and look repulsive to each other.”

The second is Bird Wick, which when lit will cause verdigris birds to fly about the house. Take the blood of a green sparrow and fashion a wick with it, adding some Iraqi verdigris to the blood; wrap the mixture in a cock’s neck skin in the shape of a wick, then wrap that in an old cloth torn from the edge of a threadbare shirt and place in a green lamp and fill with oil. When lit it will produce just this effect.

The third is Dance Wick, which when lit will cause all women in the house to dance involuntarily and ecstatically [and flirt like crazy];⁴⁴ it only works on women, and on men has no effect. Cook white hellebore until soft and wrap it in a piece of linen [as a wick], then shape some into a cup and fill with oil mixed with mercury. When lit it will produce just this effect (though God knows best).

2. Lamp wonders, comprising three operations:

The first is Water Lamp, which when lit can be placed on water and still burn. Take cow dung and dissolve it in oil of sandarac, then fashion the mixture into a wick; insert into a lamp and drizzle fresh oil on it, then fill with water – and it will burn.

The second is War Lamp, which is a pair of lamps that when lit their flames duel with one another and twist together. In one [coat the wick] with sheep fat, in the other with wolf fat – and they will fight when both are lit. It is said one can also use goat and cock fat respectively to produce the same effect.

The third is Wind Lamp, which makes whomever holds it fart. Take some ant eggs and cook them until very soft, then mix them with fig, perfume and the blood of a *chalbāsa* (a venomous lizard) and wrap in a cloth; place in the lamp, fill with oil and light. Put it in someone’s hand to make them a laughingstock – for they will uncontrollably fart.

3. Candle wonders, comprising two operations:

The first is Wood Candle: Take a piece of clean and fragrant white wood and coat in naphtha oil mixed with powdered sandarac; when lit the wood will burn bright.

The second is Ice Candle: Take a long piece of ice in the shape of a candle, hollow out an end and fill with camphor, then light – it will burn just like a candle.

4. Ring wonders, comprising three operations:

The first is Twitch Ring, meaning a ring that moves: Take a ring of iron or silver, enlarge its bezel and fill with mercury, then cover with iron or silver and solder well. When brought into contact with a precious stone or the Sun’s rays or fire or the earth itself, for example, it will indeed move.

The second is Water Ring, meaning a ring that floats on water: Take a silver ring a dram and a half in weight, no more, and fill its bezel with gum of sandarac – it will not sink.

⁴⁴As elsewhere, I add this clarifying phrase from the *Qasimian Secrets*.

The third is Fire Ring, meaning a ring that is repelled by fire: Take a steel ring, fill its bezel with mercury, then cover with silver or other metal and solder well. When placed next to fire, it will jump back and refuse to stand.

5. Bottle wonders, comprising two operations:

The first is Boil Bottle, meaning a glass bottle that boils water without fire: Take a long-necked bottle and fill it with vinegar made of pure wine and colourless like water, then add some powdered borax – it will immediately start boiling vigorously. This effect is weird when held in the hand, and weirder still when placed in the snow.

The second is Safety Bottle, meaning a glass bottle that won't break when dropped from a height: Take a bottle and fill it to bursting with feathers, then seal its cap tightly with wax – and it won't break when dropped from a height.

6. Figurine wonders, comprising one operation:

This is Figurine Now-You-See-It-Now-You-Don't, meaning it appears and disappears, whereby you sculpt two figures of wax in any shape you wish and place them in water; one will immediately sink and the other float, but after an hour they will have switched places – an operation especially lovely. Its method is as follows: Sculpt two ducks out of wax, but hollow. Fill one with salt, then make openings in the mouth and eyes; fill the other with dried and powdered watermoss (a plant that grows in rivers and generally used to fertilise fields), then make openings in its eyes. Place both in water: the one filled with salt will sink, and the one filled with watermoss (given its lightness) will float – until the salt dissolves and that duck floats up, and until the watermoss saturates and that duck sinks. It is crucial that both figurines be tested to confirm they are exactly equal in weight, and exactly which weights will allow one to float and the other to sink.

7. Cup wonders, comprising two operations:

The first is Evacuate Cup, meaning a cup that is emptied, whereby two cups full of water result in one empty and one fuller, combining their contents: Take a cup and fill it with dew (or salt- and sugar-water) and the other with regular water; as the Sun rises the cup of dew will slowly empty, evaporated by the Sun, but the water in the other will not (and the Sun has no effect on salt or sugar). When performing this operation, you must pour the water on the salt and sugar slowly and carefully.

The second is Partition Cup, meaning one that puts apart, whereby water added to wine is separated out. Its method: Use a watermoss wick (as described above) to connect two cups, one filled with a wine-water mixture and the other empty; the latter will soon fill with water and the other left with wine only, such that they will be perfectly separated.

8. Egg wonders, comprising three operations:

The first is Bottle Egg, meaning trapping an egg in a glass bottle. Its method is as follows: Take a thin, long-necked bottle and a fresh egg, then soak the latter in very strong vinegar to which is added a little saltpeter until it becomes soft; it can then be pushed into the bottle without breaking, upon which add clear freshwater until the egg resumes its normal state.

The second is Aerial Egg, meaning making an egg levitate and fly: Take a fresh pigeon egg, make an opening and extract all its contents, then dry it in a warm environment like a bathhouse; it will immediately seek to rise. Place it near the bathhouse window where it can be further warmed by the Sun, and it will immediately float up and exit the window – a wondrous sight indeed!

The third is Igneous Egg, meaning a bird egg that can be placed in fire without being burnt. Here there are two methods. The first: Boil an egg in a pot until the water is gone, refilling and repeating the process, the more times the better; the resulting egg can be placed in fire without effecting it at all. The second: Perforate an egg and empty its contents, then seal up the hole with dough – the egg will likewise remain unaffected by fire.

9. Fireplay, meaning playing with fire – a particularly impressive category of tricks with many operations. Five may be mentioned here:

The first is Mouthplay, meaning eating fire without burning one's mouth: Chew some salammioniac until very soft, spitting and adding more until it becomes very concentrated, then put red-hot iron into your mouth and rub on your tongue, and no harm will result – this is especially wondrous!

The second is Handplay, meaning holding fire in your hand without being burnt: Take arsenic and alum and pulverise thoroughly, then cook with more alum, cowblossom and some spring flowersap until firm. Pulverise and drain, then rub the resulting liquid on your hands – a potion that allows you to hold a live coal in your hand without effect.

The third is Fingerplay, meaning making your fingers burn like candles to light your party: Take dissolved talc and camphor and mix them into a dough, then coat your fingers with it; once dry, you can light all your fingers on fire like candles without harm.

The fourth is Footplay, meaning walking on fire without your feet being burnt: Take leech cotton ([sublimated fat after the Arab method]) and coat your feet with it repeatedly, including between your toes; do this at least three times, and the more times the better – you can then walk on fire. Coating your hand with it has the same effect, such that you can handle red-hot iron without harm.

The fifth is Dressplay, meaning your shirt can't be burnt when covered with live coals: Take a large, clean mirror and dissolve talc over your shirt and place it on the mirror, then watch patiently until it's all gone, then place it under coals and it won't be burnt – astonishing all party guests!

[...]

But God knows best the truth of things!

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